

To the Bahá'ís of the World

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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67 11 20 October 2008 To the Bahá'ís of the World Dearly loved Friends, 11.1 Today, the anniversary of the Birth of the Báb, marks the

midway point of the five-year enterprise that will engage the Bahá'í world until Rid .ván 2011. We bow our heads in humble gratitude to Bahá'u'lláh for the favors and confirmations He has vouchsafed unto those laboring so diligently and sacrificial- ly in the forefront of the teaching work. Since the conclusion of the Tenth International Bahá'í Convention a few months ago, there has been a rise in awareness of the efficacy of the frame- work governing the operation of the Five Year Plan as insights gained by the delegates have been widely diffused throughout the Bahá'í community. Scores of clusters around the globe are being primed for systematic expansion, and we expect to see a wave of intensive programs of growth launched in the months leading up to Rid .ván next year.

11.2 The challenge facing the friends in these and all clusters

continues to be twofold in character. While learning to identify receptive segments of society and share with responsive souls the message of the Faith—an aspiration generally not difficult to fulfill—they are striving to understand in practice how the diverse elements of a healthy pattern of growth, particularly the development of human resources, are to be integrated into a cohesive whole. How heartening it is to see that the moment the friends in a cluster begin to meet this dual challenge, immediate progress is achieved; the goal of launching an intensive program of growth becomes imminently attainable.

11.3 That the continued strengthening of the community should

be matched by a further decline in the old world order comes as no surprise. Indeed, the friends should be on their guard, lest the development of capacity in the community not keep pace with the rise in receptivity of a disillusioned humanity. Behold 68 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONhow even in the short span of time since we raised this warning in our Rid .ván message, financial structures once thought to be impregnable have tottered and world leaders have shown their inability to devise more than temporary solutions, a failing to which they increasingly confess. Whatever expedient measures are adopted, confidence has been shaken and a sense of security lost. Surely such developments have caused the believers in every land to reflect on the lamentable condition of the present order and have reinforced in them the conviction that material and spiritual civilization must be advanced together. 11.4 It is with these thoughts in mind that we turn our hearts in

frequent prayer to Bahá'u'lláh and beseech Him to strengthen His followers through His unfailing grace. In such moments, we implore Him to illumine their souls with the light of knowledge and faith. Let them not underestimate the power inherent in the system they are putting in place for the propagation of His Faith, nor mistake the true purpose of the global enterprise on which they have embarked. Let them not deviate from the path of learning on which they are set, nor be distracted by the ephemeral pursuits of a bewildered society. Let them not fail to appreciate the value of the culture now taken root in the community that

promotes the systematic study of the Creative Word in small groups in order to build capacity for service. Let them never forget the imperative to tend to the needs of the children of the world and offer them lessons that develop their spiritual faculties and lay the foundations of a noble and upright character. Let them come to realize the full significance of their efforts to help young people form a strong moral identity in their early adolescent years and empower them to contribute to the well-being of their communities. And let them rejoice at having learned through consistent, systematic action how to establish a rhythm of growth that pays due attention to the essential elements of expansion, consolidation, reflection and planning. May they one and all be endowed with constancy and fidelity and be granted the courage to make whatever sacrifices are needed to ensure the resounding success of the Plan. By the rectitude of their conduct, the sincerity of their love for their fellow human beings, and the ardor of their desire to serve the peoples of the world, may they vindicate the truth proclaimed by Bahá'u'lláh that humanity is one. May they be diligent in their efforts to establish ties of friendship that show no regard for prevalent social barriers and ceaselessly endeavor to bind

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]